

Sour Kraut!

A one-act play

By Charlie Wilke & Jake Buras

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CAST OF CHARACTERS

STANLEY, a burnt-out private eye, kicked in the pants by life.

LUCILE, a diligent assistant focused, perhaps too much, on her work.

MAURICE, a straight-laced lieutenant just doing his job.

SHNITZER, a Doctor with the greater good on his mind.

AVA, a willing participant in the Doctor's plan, also his daughter.

DOUBLE BASS, a sharp-dressed live approximation of a record player.

COSTUME PLOT

STANLEY

A cheap brown suit and tie with shoulder holster. Dress shoes.

LUCILE

A sun dress with a simple flower print, flat shoes.

MAURICE

Wide shouldered grey suit and tie. Dress shoes.

SHNITZER

Trench coat and coke-bottle glasses. Simple slacks, shirt and tie.

AVA

Tight red dress and nude heels.

DOUBLE BASS

Slacks and dress shirt. Bow tie and elastic arm band.

PROPERTY PLOT

Two desks, one for the detective adorned with a simple desk lamp, and larger than the one for the assistant. Lucile's desk will not be much larger than the typewriter that sits on top. Three chairs, one for Lucile, two surrounding the detective's desk. Double Bass. Package containing vial filled with green liquid. Backdrop of wood paneling with armature to hang it from. Three guns. Two glasses and a bottle of bourbon.

SCENE 1

THE SCENE: Bright and early at STANLEY C. CLARKE's Private Investigator office. A modest space, filled with the bare essentials. Wood-paneled walls, a small desk and lamp, and a few chairs.

AT RISE: LUCILE, a woman in a nebulous time of early-mid womanhood sits clacking away at a typewriter down-right at her own small desk.

A DOUBLE BASS player stands in the corner of the office and is treated merely as a record player by all.

A MAN stands further inside the office listening to the DOUBLE BASS as if it were a recording. He taps along, maybe snapping a little. He's a hulking mass, dressed in a fine, wide-shouldered suit.

A disheveled and gangly STANLEY C. CLARKE enters in a huff and stops at Lucile's desk. He doesn't initially see the man in his office.

STANLEY

(addressing LUCILE)

Landlord's dog got out again, Lucile. Chased me damn near three blocks!

LUCILE

(focused on her typewriter)

Well, that explains the odor, Mr. Clarke!

(LUCILE waves her hand in front of her nose. Backing up in her seat ever so slightly.)

STANLEY

Sure got the blood pumping. I don't think I'll need coffee this morning!

LUCILE

Speak for yourself!

(LUCILE clacks away on her typewriter.)

LUCILE

(while typing)

The lieutenant let himself in again.

(STANLEY's shoulders drop, he looks to the ground then to Lucile.)

STANLEY

Yeah, I think I'm gonna need something stronger than coffee.

(STANLEY enters his office. The LIEUTENANT doesn't turn, he keeps tapping his foot.

STANLEY throws his jacket on his chair, sits and gets situated behind his desk.

While sitting, he attempts numerous postures and positions before saying anything. He gesticulates as he's about to begin, stops himself, then attempts again, until...)

LIEUTENANT

Late again!

(The LIEUTENANT turns to face STANLEY.)

LIEUTENANT

And I can smell you from across the room! Jesus man, did you run here?

STANLEY

Yeah, actually. For a stretch.

(STANLEY repositions and points a finger at his visitor.)

STANLEY

You know, you could use a few laps yourself, Mo.

LIEUTENANT

That's Lieutenant Maurice Callahan to you, Stanley.

(The moment is tense. STANLEY throws his arms in the air then behind his head and stares down MAURICE.)

MAURICE releases a deep belly laugh and STANLEY instantly disarms.

STANLEY reaches down and pulls out glasses and a bottle of bourbon.)

STANLEY

(pouring two stiff drinks)

Will you ever stop pulling rank, dingleberry?

MAURICE

Will you ever leave the schoolyard?

(MAURICE sits.)

STANLEY

Hey, those were my finest days! And you certainly never complained about all those answer keys I grabbed for you.

MAURICE

Well, you're lucky I still have a use for unlawful degenerates like yourself. In fact, that's why I'm here! Something's gone missing. Something incredibly dangerous in the wrong hands. Ever heard of Acute Vibrio Pneumococcal Pan-sepsis?

STANLEY

Acute Pan-whatsis?

MAURICE

In short... The plague!

*(STANLEY's eyes go wide, as he
lowers his glass to the desk.)*

STANLEY

Oh wow, you should **not** have lost that!

MAURICE

Well, we intend this loss of possession to be a temporary issue. That's where you come in.

(STANLEY recoils in his chair.)

STANLEY

Whoa, hey now, I don't think I've even got all my shots!

LUCILE

(over her shoulder)

Nope, you're all up to date, Mr. C!

*(STANLEY snaps to himself in
disappointment.)*

MAURICE

No is not an available option for **you**, Stan. Your government needs you to track down a kraut.

*(STANLEY gets up and walks to the
edge of his desk.)*

STANLEY

The Germans. Damn.

MAURICE

Yes, our suspect is Doctor Heinrich Shnitzer, he was the head of our research team downtown, and now he's AWOL. We believe he stole the sample and is now hiding out somewhere on the east side.

STANLEY

So he takes out a few hippies. Great, he did the world a service.

(MAURICE stands and walks towards the detective, growing increasingly agitated.)

MAURICE

We need you to find him before he weaponizes it. Imagine: filling the balloons of the Thanksgiving Day Parade with the most deadly airborne disease known to man! The immediate casualties would be catastrophic!! The spread of contagion, unrelenting!!

(MAURICE collects himself.)

MAURICE

I need you to find that stolen sample, destroy whatever work has been done, and secure the threat before I come back tonight.

STANLEY

I prefer you **don't** come back!

(MAURICE throws his arm around STANLEY.)

MAURICE

We appreciate your discretion in finding our man. You've not let us down yet. Don't you start now.

(MAURICE exits.)

LUCILE

What a free spirit!

(STANLEY resets, the BASS plays, he clears the drinks from his desk. He sits back down and rubs his head.)

*Then **she** enters. A Sultry vixen, big hair, red dress, high heels. Her name: AVA SHNITZER.*

She walks with a noticeable wobble in her step, only on a single side.

AVA stumbles slightly getting on the stage, then anchors herself on LUCILE's typing desk.)

LUCILE

Hands off the hardware, honey.

(waves her hand in front of her nose)

And lay off the Chanel!

(AVA lets herself into the office.

STANLEY looks up from having his head in his hands. His eyes go wide just as AVA hides her wobble by grabbing on to the back of the chair. The BASS stops playing.

AVA attempts to fix her hair and hit a sexy pose all while clinging to the back of that chair.)

STANLEY

Would you like to have a seat?

AVA

Do I entice you?

STANLEY

Uhh. Yeah. Yes. Yes. Yes you do.

(collects himself)

But, to whom do I owe the pleasure?

AVA

Shnitzer. Ava. Shnitzer.

STANLEY

Lovely name, sounds so familiar. Is it Slavic?

(STANLEY leans down to grab glasses and the bottle of bourbon.)

AVA

No actually, it's German.

*(Stanley shakes his fist while
leaning down profile to Ava.)*

STANLEY

(sotto)

The Germans!

*(STANLEY rises and sets the bottle
and glasses on the table.)*

STANLEY

(while pouring drinks)

Well Ava, I'd bet dollars to donuts you know I'm looking for
your pops.

AVA

He needs... Time.

STANLEY

Sorry honey, but I'm on a bit of a tight schedule.

AVA

*(hitting her most seductive,
pouty pose)*

I've been told to delay you by any means... necessary.

*(AVA stands, her legs buckle,
unable to stand still. She wobbles
towards the downstage edge of the
desk.*

*STANLEY rises out of his seat to
catch AVA before she falls.)*

AVA

Nein! Get off me, you ape!

*(AVA pushes herself away and stands
tall.*

Then.

*She pulls the heels off and shrinks
a good few inches.)*

AVA

Two masters degrees in physics and I still can't figure these damn things out...

STANLEY

You wore them well and that's what counts.

(AVA chortles.)

AVA

(gestures with shoes in hand)

Listen to me, you have to give my father time. You don't understand. My father's intentions with the virus sample are benign.

STANLEY

Benign? Like my neck mole?

AVA

No! Like a Cure! Your government is lying to you. **They** are the ones who wish to weaponize it! My father wants to build a vaccine. Nothing more.

STANLEY

But your father still stole it, right? It's the property of the US Government, and I've been tasked with recovering it... and let's just say... if I fail, it'll be my ass!

AVA

Your ass or hundreds of millions dead?

(maps path with her shoes)

This could spread from New York... All the way... to San Francisco in a matter of days!

STANLEY

Well, I happen to like my ass.

AVA

Ugh... you idiot.

*(AVA storms off, heels in hand. She
pauses downstage, turns back and
points a shoe at STANLEY.)*

AVA

Do not interfere, Stanley C. Clarke. For your own good.

(AVA exits.)

LUCILE

That went well.

(The BASS plays. STANLEY rubs his brow then grabs his glass from his desk and downs the drink.)

He sighs, grabs his coat and heads towards the exit. The BASS stops as STANLEY approaches to address Lucile. She types as he speaks.)

STANLEY

The plague? Isn't that, like, history stuff? Now, I know I'm not getting paid to ask questions, but that Ava sure did look good in those heels. And even if she's telling the truth about this cure, a guy's gotta eat, so I guess I'm off to find that dirty kraut.

LUCILE

(without looking up)

Yeah, you go get 'em, Mr. C.

(STANLEY exits the stage.)

INTERLUDE

The BASS plays while Lucile sits clacking at her typewriter.

A FRAIL MAN enters. His coke-bottle glasses and pronounced hunch pair nicely with his trench coat. He's holding a small PACKAGE.

His stride is measured if not a little labored. As he steps on stage, he leans in to LUCILE.)

MAN

I'm not here, and **this** is not a thing.

(He enters the office. And as LUCILE speaks, the man places the package on STANLEY's desk and hides behind the BASS player.)

LUCILE

He doesn't pay me enough to see anything but this typewriter, honey.

(STANLEY returns.)

STANLEY

Do you know how many Shnitzers there are on the east side?

LUCILE

(nonplussed)

Thousands, Mr. C.?

STANLEY

At least!

(STANLEY enters his office and throws his jacket over the chair as he notices the package on his desk.)

STANLEY

Lucile! Did someone come by while I was out?

(As LUCILE responds, STANLEY scrutinizes the package, opens it and removes a small vial filled with green liquid.)

LUCILE

Oh honey, you hardly pay me enough to see the keys right in front of me. Now if you want to increase the circumference of my view... That'll cost ya!

STANLEY

(shaking the vial towards

LUCILE)

Initiative, Lucile! Initiative!

(STANLEY holds the vial filled to his forehead to get a real good look at the contents.)

LUCILE

But now that you mention it, there may or may not be a man hiding on your office. I don't know...

STANLEY

What?!

(The man shifts out from behind the BASS player holding a PISTOL.)

MAN

You really need to pay your secretary better, Herr Clarke!

(STANLEY turns mouth agape.)

STANLEY

Doctor Shnitzer?!

SHNITZER

One in the same!

LUCILE

Ooh, sounds like you've got a German in there, Mr. C.!

STANLEY

Yeah, Lucile! Unfortunately, I do!

SHNITZER

I must say, Stanley. I'm disappointed in your institutionalized distrust of the German people. We are not all bad. Some of us want to do great good!

STANLEY

By stealing the plague?!

SHNITZER

(points to the vial)

And creating das cure!

STANLEY

And pointing a gun at me?!!

SHNITZER

Formalities, Herr Clarke. I'm a wanted man, by now my face is in every post office. I need **you** to send this vial to Geneva. To people who care about saving lives!

STANLEY

So, would now be a weird time to reach for my gun?

(MAURICE enters whistling as LUCILE begins to type and the BASS fills in the bottom end.

He hops on stage and leans down to LUCILE.)

MAURICE

Don't you be working too hard now, Lucile. He's not worth carpal tunnel. Mind if I head in?

LUCILE

You wouldn't listen if I said no...

(MAURICE chuckles and walks in. He surveys the scene. From his perspective, he sees a relatively tense STANLEY and the back of SHNITZER. He doesn't see the gun.)

MAURICE

Ah! You found the Kraut ahead of schedule!

(claps SHNITZER's shoulders)

Great! It's gonna be a home-by-five kind of day!

(looking down he sees the gun, recoils and pulls his own)

Sweet Jesus!

STANLEY

(motioning to SHNITZER)

This nice German says he only stole your plague sample to make a **cure**. Isn't that right, Doctor?

SHNITZER

(nodding)

Yes, to save the lives of millions!

MAURICE

Well you see, Doctor Shnitzer, that's very much the problem! There's far. Too. Many. Of. Us! We can't feed everyone. We're making quite a mess of the Earth. And there's just so. Many. Imbeciles.

STANLEY

Hey, I take offense to that!

MAURICE

(to STANLEY)

Quiet you. You'll get your money.

STANLEY

Yeah sure, a lot of good that'll do me if I'm dead from the plague!

MAURICE

We need to limit the human population in order to survive! Yes Doctor, for the **greater good**.

SHNITZER

Greater good? No, we call what you're doing something different where I come from: Genocide. What makes you think you deserve to decide who lives and who dies?

MAURICE

I leave that up to my superiors in the U.S. Government. Specifically: the bureau of Happy Live Long Time.

STANLEY

And you think **I** need to leave the schoolyard...

SHNITZER

Schoolyard? Yes! Think of the **children**!

MAURICE

The fit will survive.

SHNITZER

And the rest?

MAURICE

The plague! It'll replace sugar. We've been using sweets to cull the flock for years, but it just. Takes. So. Damn. Long!

SHNITZER

You fiend! The explosive rise in diabetes. Heart disease. Obesity! It's all you! Mine God.

MAURICE

Yes, but the plague is far more efficient! Our species will strengthen and thrive. The casualties will be a necessary cost to survival.

SHNITZER

One government should not dictate the future.

(raises his gun)

I cannot allow this injustice to continue!

(SHNITZER shoots and STANLEY instinctively pushes him so his shot lands off target. The bullet hits MAURICE in the shoulder. SHNITZER falls over the desk.

MAURICE lists backwards slightly, then laughs.)

MAURICE

Thanks Stan... You just saved me a mountain of paperwork. Now this is simply self defense.

(MAURICE shoots SHNITZER square in the chest as the DOCTOR is attempting to right himself. This leaves SHNITZER just enough time to brace himself on the desk and deliver one hell of a last line.)

SHNITZER

Oh, you asshole!

(to STANLEY)

You nincompoop.

(SHNITZER dies and drapes over the desk.

STANLEY looks up at MAURICE holstering his weapon.)

MAURICE

I'll be needing that vial, Stan.

STANLEY

I've been through a lot today, Mo. How about I keep it here?
You know, as part of my payment?

MAURICE

To get paid, you'll need to hand it over, Mr. Clarke.

*(STANLEY hesitates. MAURICE pulls
his gun and points it at STANLEY.)*

MAURICE

You know you wouldn't be much more paperwork.

*(STANLEY immediately throws his
hands over his head, the vial flies
over to MAURICE, who catches it
easily and pockets it.)*

MAURICE

You've made Uncle Sam a happy man today.

STANLEY

So, if this plague of yours gets me in the end, do I at least
get a statue in my honor?

*(MAURICE hoists SHNITZER over his
shoulder and begins to walk off. He
turns back to look at STANLEY.)*

MAURICE

Well, if that happens, maybe we can add your name to the
memorial plaque at the bureau. But, if you open your mouth
about any of this... we'll pin the outbreak on you.

*(MAURICE smiles and slaps a wad of
cash on the desk.)*

MAURICE

This should keep you fed for a few months. The bureau of
Happy Live Long Time will be in touch.

*(MAURICE turns and leaves. He
pauses as he passes LUCILE.)*

MAURICE

What did you see, Lucile?

LUCILE

Just these keys, Lieutenant.

MAURICE

That's a girl.

*(MAURICE exits. LUCILE starts
typing as the BASS begins again.)*

*STANLEY shakes his head as he
reaches for his jacket.*

*He grabs the money off his desk,
looks at it in his hand, sighs then
pockets it.)*

STANLEY

Well Lucile, I'd say there's a fifty-fifty shot I end this
day a good guy!

LUCILE

Oh, you think highly of yourself!

*(LUCILE turns to look at STANLEY
for the first time.)*

LUCILE

But after today, I'm not sure what good means anymore.

STANLEY

Well, to me, good means taking care of your own... How about
tomorrow we talk about a raise?

LUCILE

(sarcastic)

Oh, my hero.

*(STANLEY laughs to himself and
looks off above the audience for a
beat.)*

STANLEY
(sotto)

Hero...

*(STANLEY snaps back to reality,
acknowledges LUCILE, knocks twice
on her desk then on exit:)*

STANLEY
Lock it up tight, would ya?

LUCILE
(calling after him)
Always do!
(sotto)
Always do.

*(LUCILE clacks away as the BASS
plays to BLACKOUT.)*